



WMSU

SYSTEMS INTEGRATION



What is System Integration?

- Systems integration means that you allow a heterogeneous (hodgepodge) IS to communicate or integrate and share information (or data) **seamlessly** with one another.
- Systems integration is a key issue for an organization for its growth - Management needs to pay close attention to this issue.
- ERP systems are a major kind of enterprise information system allowing organizations to integrate different systems into one organization-wide application with an integrated database management system.



Functional Silos

- Silos are basically compartmentalized operating units isolated from their environment.

Horizontal Silos

- The POSDCORB (Planning, Organizing, Staffing, Directing, Coordinating, Reporting and Budgeting) categorization by Luther Gulick led to a set of formal organization functions such as control, management, supervision, and administration starting in late 1930s.
- Classification of organizations into departments like Accounting and Human Resources, reflects the breaking of complex tasks into smaller manageable tasks that could be assigned to a group of people who could then be held responsible.

Figure 2-1 Functional Model of Organization (POSDCORB)



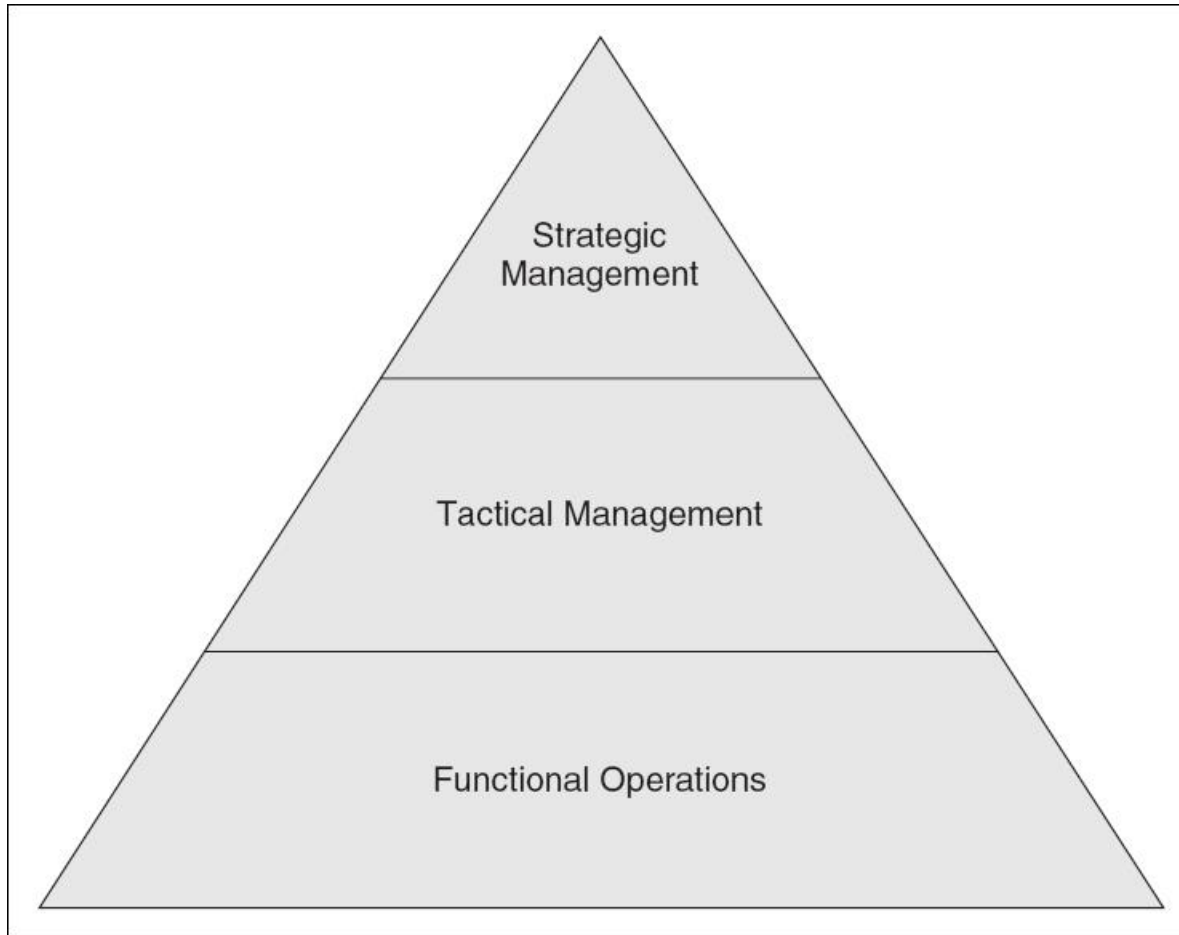


Functional Silos (Cont'd)

Vertical Silos

- Organizations also divided roles in hierarchical layers from strategic planning to management control and operation control.
- CEOs and Presidents plan long-term strategy, midlevel management focuses on tactical issues and on the execution of organizational policy whereas the lower-level management task is to focus on the day-to-day operations of the company.
- As organizations get big and complex they tend to break functions into smaller units and assign staff the responsibility for these activities allowing them to manage complexity as well as specialize in activities that enhance productivity and efficiency.

Figure 2-2 Hierarchical Model of Organization

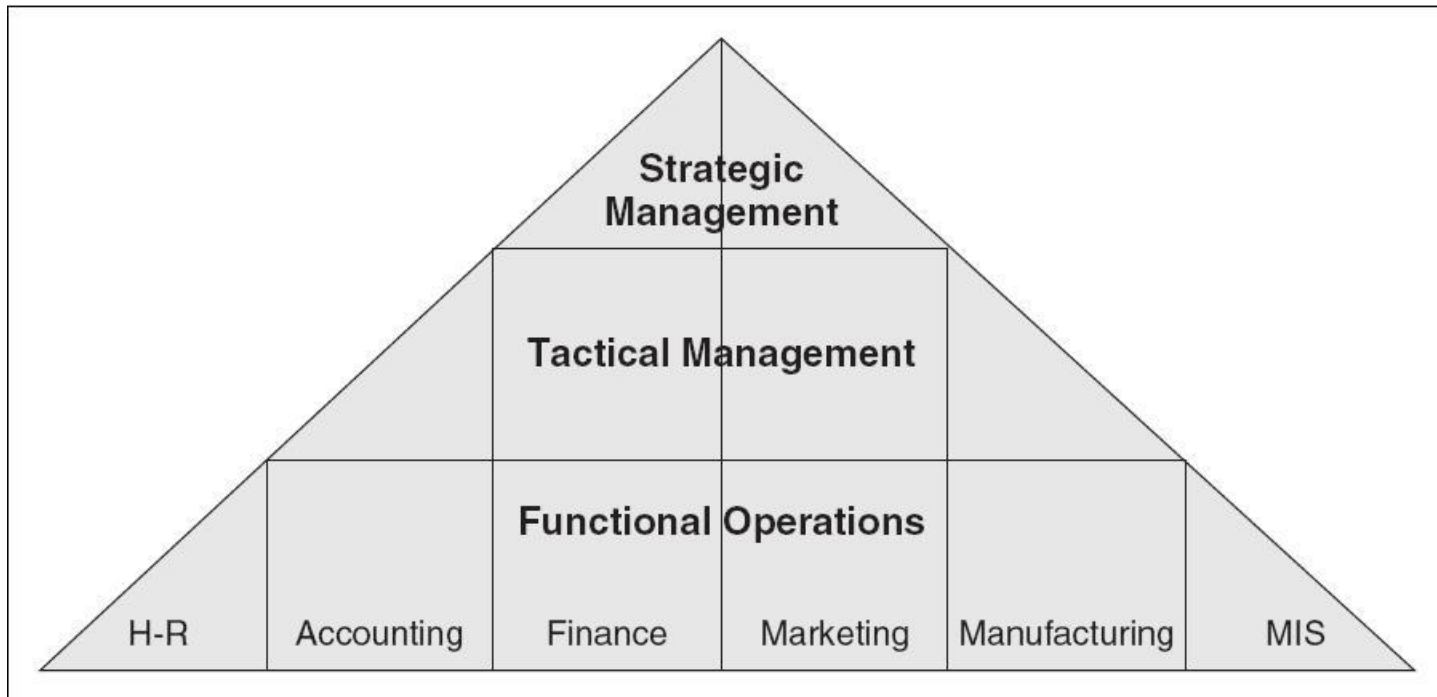




Business Process and Silos

- The problem of functional silos gave birth to business process re-engineering (BPR).
- The cross-functional business process can involve people and resources from various functional departments working together, sharing information at any level of the organization.
- The cross-functional organizational structure breaks the functional silos by opening up the informational flows from one department to another.

Figure 2-3 Matrix Structure of Organization

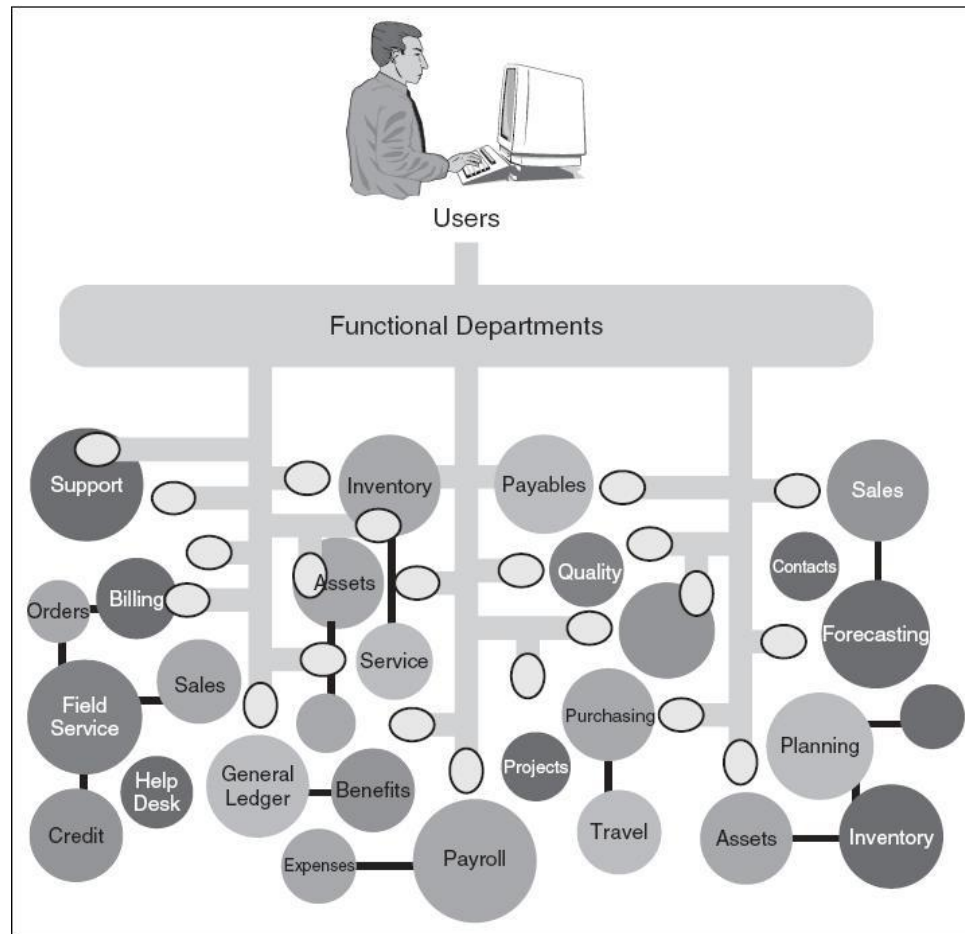


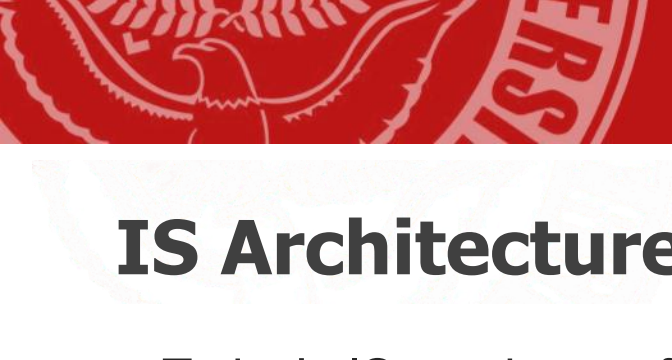


Evolution of Information Systems in Organizations

- The functions of an organization (e.g., sales, manufacturing, and HR) are important as they provide a structure by which an organization functions smoothly.
- A silo information system is inefficient, inaccurate, and expensive.
 - The system creates bottlenecks for everyone and information is not available in real-time.
- The evolution of IS suggests that its role has generally been to support evolving information needs of the organization.

Figure 2-4 Functional Silos in Organization





IS Architectures

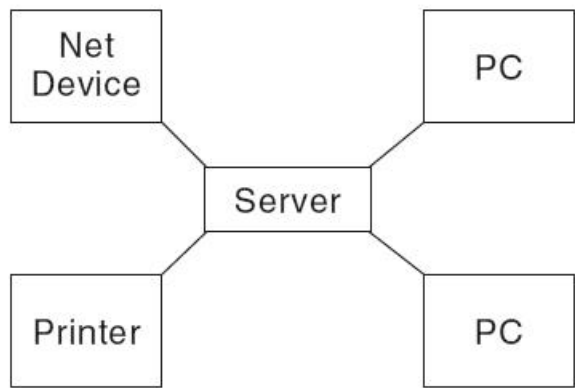
- Today's IS can be configured using a wide range of system architectures depending on the information needs of the organization.
- Rapid advances in computer and networking technologies and changing organizational dynamics, drive the emergence of new information system models.
- Web-based systems today use a distributed architecture which allows the sharing of applications and data resources between the client and the server computers.
- In this configuration, personal computers are connected via a network to a Web server that provides a window to an application and database server, which could be a mainframe or another type of computer.



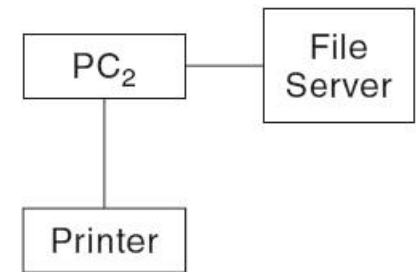
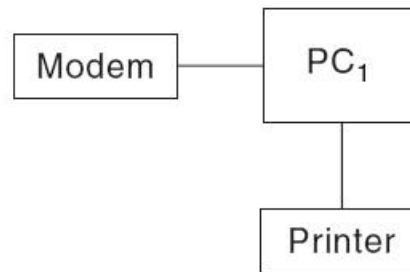
IS Functionalization

- In addition to serving the different management levels, IS also supports major business functions, such as manufacturing, marketing, accounting, finance, and HR.
- Each functional area has different information needs and report requirements.
- Each functional area in an organization also has multiple levels of management, each requiring different levels of analysis and details of information.

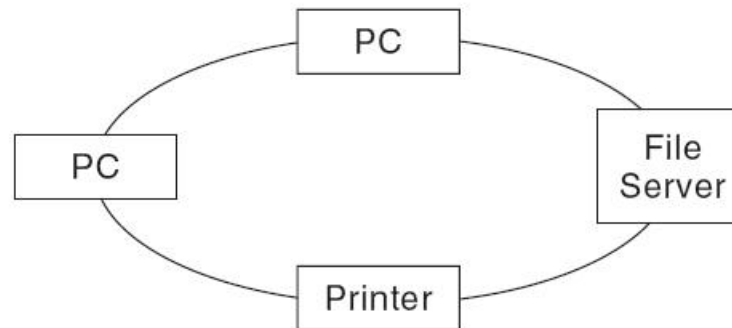
Figure 2-5 Information Systems Architectures



CENTRALIZED

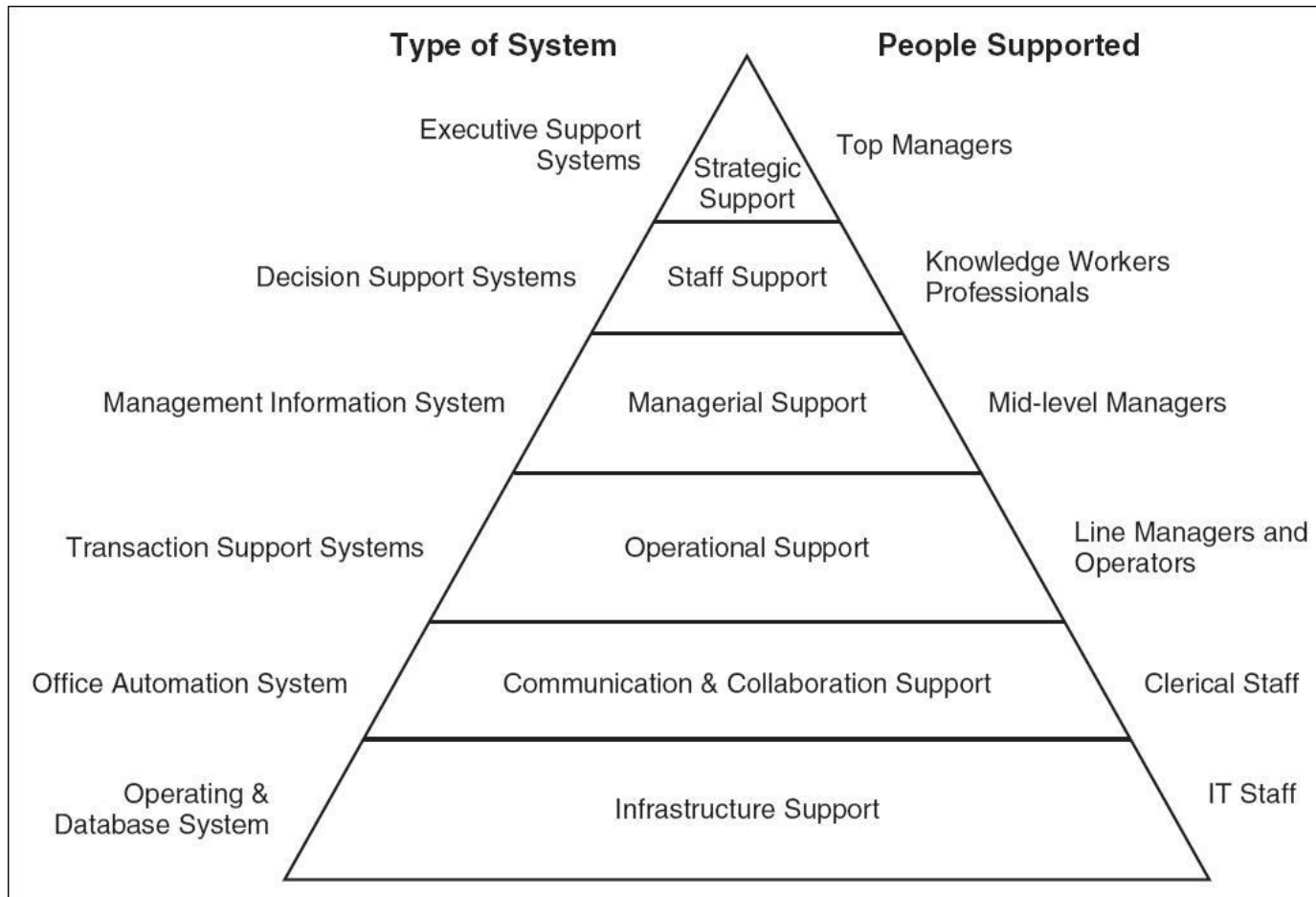


DECENTRALIZED



DISTRIBUTED

Figure 2-6 IS as Categorized by Functional and Hierarchical Models





Systems Integration

Logical (Human Level)

- Develop information systems that allow organizations to share data with all of its stakeholders based on need and authorization.
- Management needs to change organizational structures, processes, and employee roles and responsibilities.

Physical (Technical Level)

- Provide seamless connectivity between heterogeneous systems.
- Business process reengineering involves changing the mindset of the employees in the organization, encouraging and enabling them to do their tasks in a new way.

Steps in Integrating Systems

TABLE 2-1 System Integration Steps

Step 1	Resource categorization	Take an inventory of the various hardware and software resources focusing on vendors, operating systems platform, IS architecture used in these resources.
Step 2	Compliance and standards	Check whether the database and other technologies used in various applications are such supporting standards as JDBC/ODBC compliance for databases.
Step 3	Legacy systems support	Develop a policy in support of older legacy applications.
Step 4	Middleware tools	Think of middleware tools because most organizations will not dispose of their old system right away for systems integration. Middleware tools are essential for integration in the short term—if existing applications must be used by the organization.
Step 5	Authentication and authorization policies	Develop a single sign-on policy for application and data access because all employees and external partners will need access to an integrated system from anywhere, anytime.
Step 6	Centralized IT services and help desk support	Instituting IT support for an integrated systems environment is necessary to avoid support and maintenance problems with the integrated system. Centralization does not mean that they are all physically in one location. The IT staff can be all over the organization, but they need to be able to support all applications and platforms with a centralized IT help desk support.
Step 7	Backup, recovery, and security policies	Planning data and disaster recovery for organization's data in an integrated system IT is crucial for building the trust and confidence for the new system. A good backup and recovery system is essential if there is a system failure or a major disaster.
Step 8	Hardware and software standardization policies	Develop organization standards and policy on acquisition of new hardware and software which are aligned with organization IT strategy.



Benefits and Limitations of Systems Integration

Benefits	Limitations
Increased Revenue and Growth	High Initial Set-up Costs
Leveling the Competitive Environment	Power and Interdepartmental Conflicts (due to the sharing of information)
Enhanced Information Visibility	Long-term and Intangible ROI (Usually several years)
Increased Standardization	Creativity Limitations (Restricts Creativity and Independence)



ERP and Systems Integration

- Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) systems are integrated, multi-module application software packages designed to serve and support several business functions across an organization.
- ERP systems are typically commercial software packages that facilitate collection and integration of information related to various areas of an organization.
- ERP systems enable the organization to standardize and improve its business processes to implement best practices for its industry.



ERP's Role in Logical Integration

- ERP systems require organizations to focus on business process rather than on functions.
- ERP systems come with built-in processes for a wide variety of common business functions.
- An ERP system implements best practices via specific built-in steps for processing a customer order in terms of:
 - order entry.
 - routing through departments.
 - communication of output to various parties.



ERP's Role in Physical Integration

- Before installing the ERP system, an organization may have to upgrade or install middleware or get rid of their legacy system's hardware and software.
- Integration is also required at the Data level, Client level, and at the Application level.
- A good ERP implementation improves operational efficiency with better business processes that focuses on organizational goals rather than on individual departmental goals.
- Improved efficiency with a paperless flow and electronic data interchange (EDI) or business-to-business (B2B) commerce environment with partners.



Implications for Management

- **Silos do not work.**
 - Most organizations lose out in the long-term when information is not shared in real time across the functional boundaries within the company.
- **System integration has many hidden benefits.**
 - Allows decision making to be cascaded to all departments
 - Allows employees at lower-levels to make better decisions while interacting with clients or partners.
- **System integration has many challenges.**
 - Replacing old hardware and software
 - Working with IT consultants
 - Human challenges, such as impact on IT staff, department heads losing control of data, and rumors of layoffs



Implications for Management (Cont'd)

- **Systems integration raises many new ethical issues.**
 - Possibility of some employees exploiting information for personal advantage and illegal access of information.
- Remedies can consist of:
 - Develop policies on ethical usage of information.
 - Install proper security software and hardware (like firewalls).
 - Allocate resources for training and education on accessing information.



WMSU

SYSTEMS INTEGRATION